

How to Get Your Ham Radio License

It's easier than you think — and RVARC can help

Getting licensed as an amateur radio operator opens the door to a worldwide community of hobbyists, emergency communicators, and technology enthusiasts. There are three license classes, each built on the one before it.

Class	Exam	What You Can Do
Tech Technician	35 questions, passing score 26/35. No Morse code required. Most people pass with 4–8 hours of study.	Full privileges on VHF/UHF bands (2 meters, 70 cm, etc.) — local and regional communications, repeaters, satellite, and more.
General General	35 questions on top of Technician knowledge. Passing score 26/35. Adds HF (shortwave) theory.	HF privileges on most frequencies — communicate coast-to-coast and internationally without the internet.
Extra Amateur Extra	50 questions, passing score 37/50. Most advanced exam. Deepest technical knowledge.	Full HF privileges including exclusive Extra-class portions of every band. Top tier of amateur radio.

How to Study

Free Online Resources

- HamStudy.org — free question pool practice, tracks your readiness
- ARRL.org — official question pools and study guides
- HamRadioPrep.com — video-based course
- YouTube — search "Technician license study" for free video walkthroughs

Books

- ARRL Ham Radio License Manual — the standard beginner guide
- Gordon West study guides — popular, very readable

How long does it take?

Most people pass the Technician exam with 4–8 hours of focused practice using the free online question pool. The exam has 35 questions; you need 26 correct to pass.

Taking the Exam

Exams are administered by Volunteer Examiners (VEs) — licensed hams who give up their time to help new operators get licensed. The exam fee is typically \$15 or less.

- RVARC hosts VE exam sessions — dates are posted at rvarc.club and announced at monthly meetings
- You can also find exam sessions nationwide at arrl.org/find-an-amateur-radio-license-exam-session
- Exams can also be taken online via remote proctoring — ask any RVARC member for details

RVARC Can Help

Not sure where to start? Talk to any RVARC member here today. We run license exam sessions, offer mentoring for new hams (Elmers), and our monthly Tech Night is a great place to get hands-on help with radios and equipment.

Learn more and find upcoming exam dates at rvarc.club